

start looking for a lawyer since he had effectively ‘killed’ his company. Some mentioned submitting the drives to data recovery experts although chances of success in such cases were very low. Still others were skeptical regarding the authenticity of the entire incident partly due to the mind bogglingly mismanaged and poorly designed architecture, criticizing the user for being careless enough to allow something like this to happen.

The incident if true, would no doubt have cost the provider a large sum of money to either restore his hard drives, or when his clients sued him for destroying their data.

Death by ambulance (1992):

The London Ambulance Service catered to 6.8 million people living in a 600 square mile area in the year 1992. It had 318 emergency ambulances, of which on an average 212 were in service at any given time. The service received anywhere, between 2000 and 2500 calls daily, 60% of which were requests for emergency services.

The morning of October 26, 1992 saw a new software being deployed to automate the entire process of handling calls and dispatching ambulances to the requested locations. Just a few hours later, however, problems began to arise. The software was unable to keep track of the ambulances in the system. It began sending multiple units to some locations and no units to other locations. The system began to



When SOS calls are answered by software

generate a great quantity of exception messages on the terminals. The problem was compounded when people called back more because the ambulances they called had did not arrive. As more and more data was entered into the system, it became increasingly clogged. The next day, the LAS switched back to a part-manual system, and later had to shut down the computer system completely when it quit working altogether eight days later.

Because of the size of the area serviced by the LAS, many people were directly affected by the failure. There were as many as 46 deaths that would have been avoided had the requested ambulance arrived on time.